> Soviet commander could have put a low-yield atomic warhead on a short-range cruise missile. If such an officer had also found a target for that weapon, it is hard to believe that he would have waited long for approval from higher authority before firing.[91]

Journeys to Doomsday

How do you get to Armageddon from the Bermuda Triangle? How do you get there from the North Pole? Or from a forest near Guantánamo Bay? Counterfactual history, wargaming scenarios, or creative fiction, can chart innumerable pathways. These have great value in reimagining the past. Not all of them lead to Armageddon (and beyond). An interesting example is provided in a 2004 counterfactual essay by Robert O'Connell, in which he describes 'The Two Day's War' that results in 'The Second Holocaust'. [92]

The war begins on 27 October 1962, when Captain Shumkov's B-130 destroys the USS *Randolph* with a nuclear torpedo. US retaliation against the MRBM sites in Cuba in turn provokes Soviet attacks on Guantánamo and against US warships using tactical nuclear missiles. The two surviving MRBMs are launched at the United States: one fails to detonate; the other destroys Washington. This provokes a 'full retaliatory response' against the USSR, launched by General Power (who inexplicably withholds attacks on the People's Republic of China). In the USSR, 233 million people die within a month. The Soviet Union 'suffered something close to extermination'.[93] Ninety-five per cent of Cubans die in the nuclear war on their territory. 'Nuclear Twilight' brings starvation around the world and millions die in famines across India and China caused by radioactive fallout. A quarter of a million Americans perish, but as the United States remains intact, the United States prevails. God has blessed America (at least those dwelling outside Washington).

What if?

All history involves asking, in different ways, the question of 'what if?' Had Richard Nixon been President in October 1962, would Nikita Khrushchev